

Why Robins Hop

Adapted by Annette Carruthers

Illustrated by Chris Baldwin



Literature • Pourquoi Tale

Grade	1	Word Count	250	Learning A–Z	level I
Lexile	450L			Multi-level	N/A

Refer to the Focus Question on page 2 of this title to guide discussion and support additional learning connected to the text.

According to legend, once all birds walked the same way and left the same tracks. In this entertaining pourquoi tale readers discover how birds came to have their own distinct footprints.

Adapted from Nature Myths: Why Some Birds Hop, by Margaret W. Metcalfe, 1913

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Focus Question
Why is it better to work
together than to work alone?



Once, many years ago, all the birds
of the world met together.

They had a problem.

It all started when foxes began to chase robins.

Foxes normally chased chickens.

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One day, a fox followed the tracks of a chicken.
Or so it thought.
The tracks really belonged to a robin.
At that time, all the birds had the same tracks!

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Chickens knew to run from foxes.
Robins did not.
So the fox easily chased the robins.
The robins were tired of being chased.

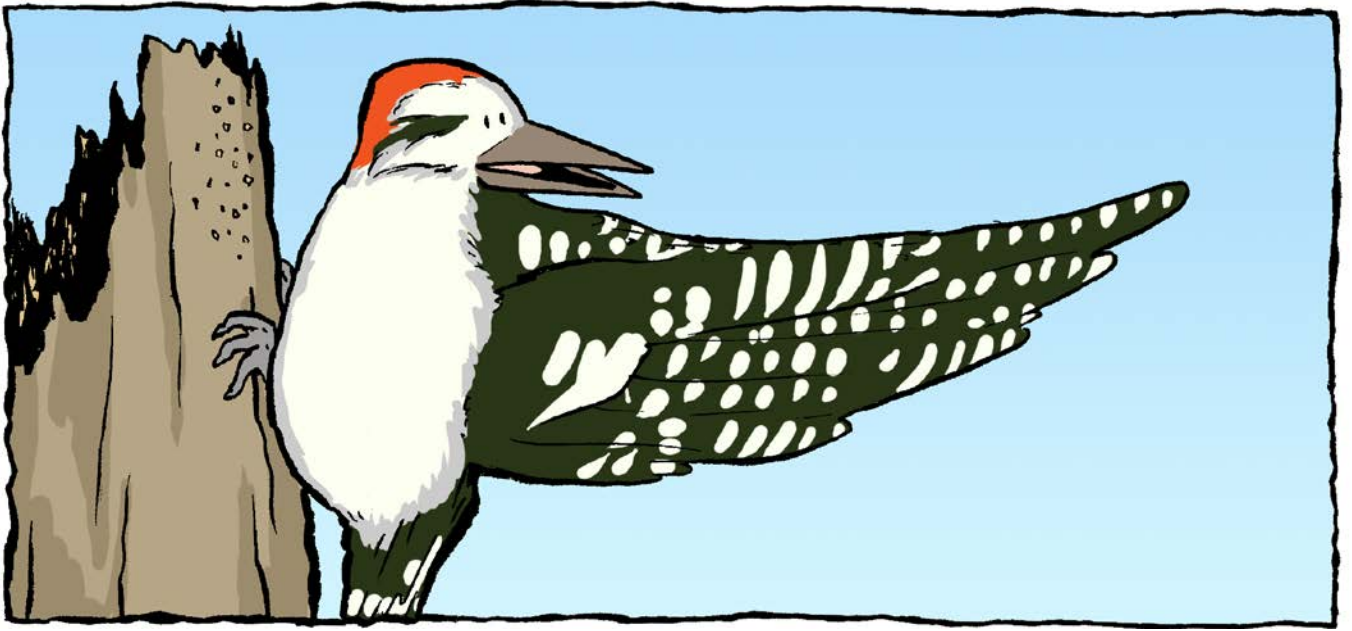
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All the birds met.
They wanted to protect robins from foxes.
They needed a plan.
Owl asked, "What can be done?"





Woodpecker said, "Let robins fly all the time.
Or make them stay in the trees."

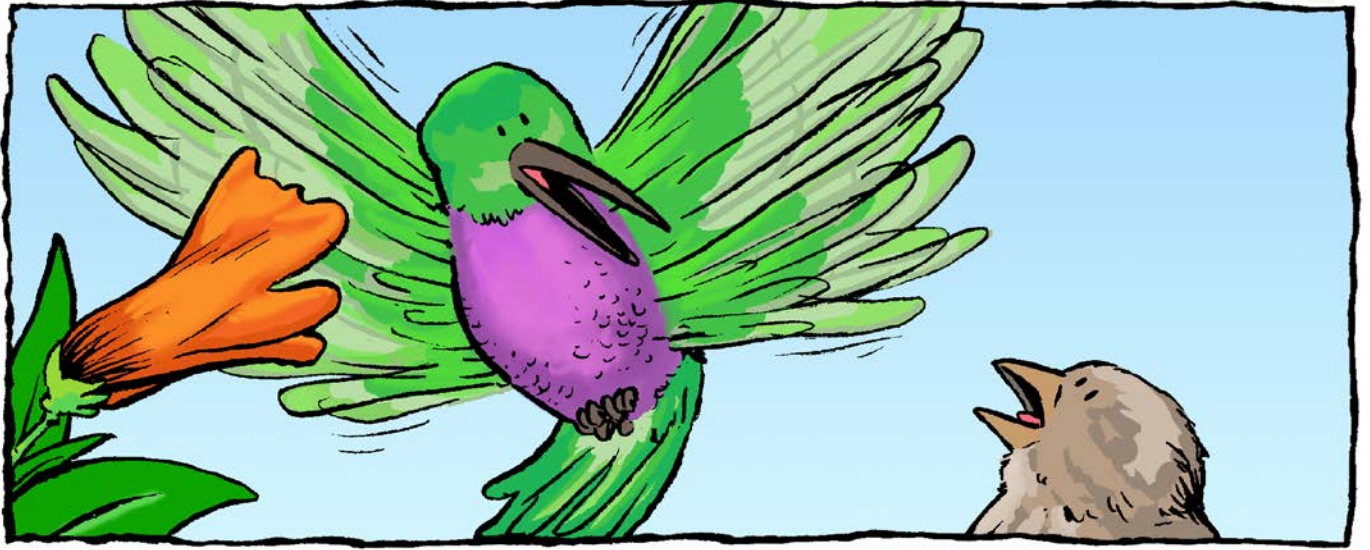
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Crow did not like this plan.
He knew that robins ate worms from the dirt.
"Robins must walk on the ground," he said.

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Hummingbird said, "Let robins eat from flowers."
 "That won't work either," said Sparrow.
 "Robins don't have proper beaks."

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The birds thought.
 They talked, and they thought some more.

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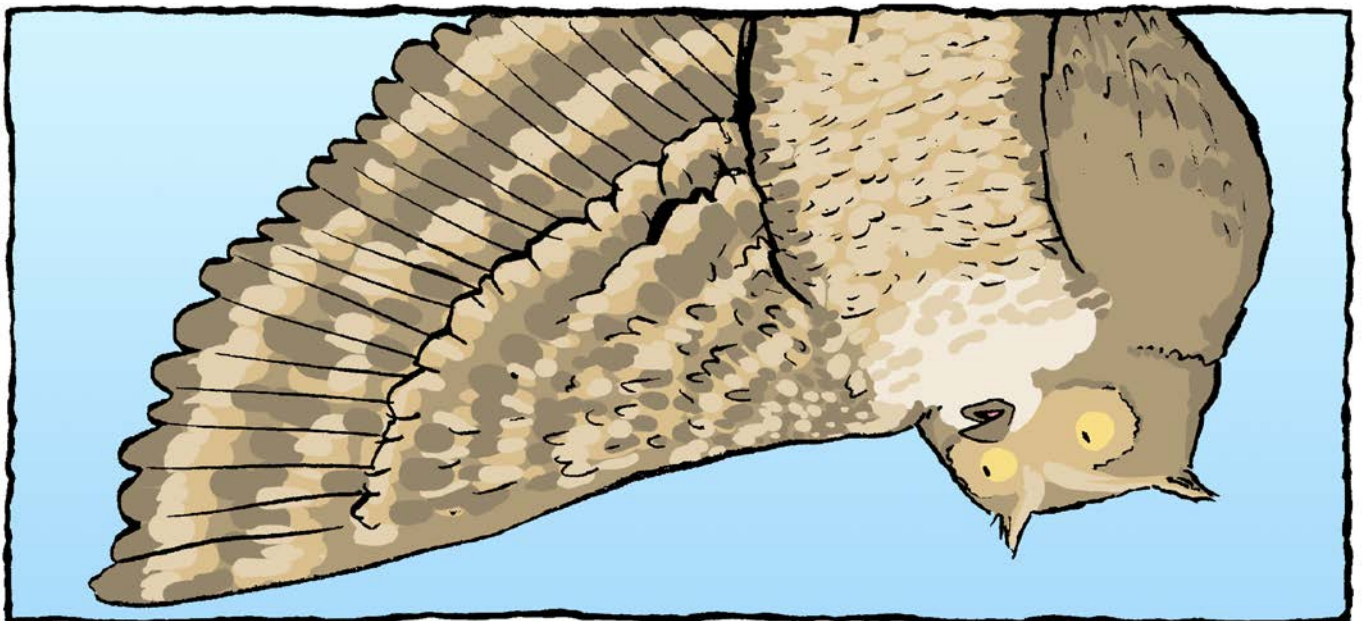
Finally, Owl said, "Let robins hop on both feet."

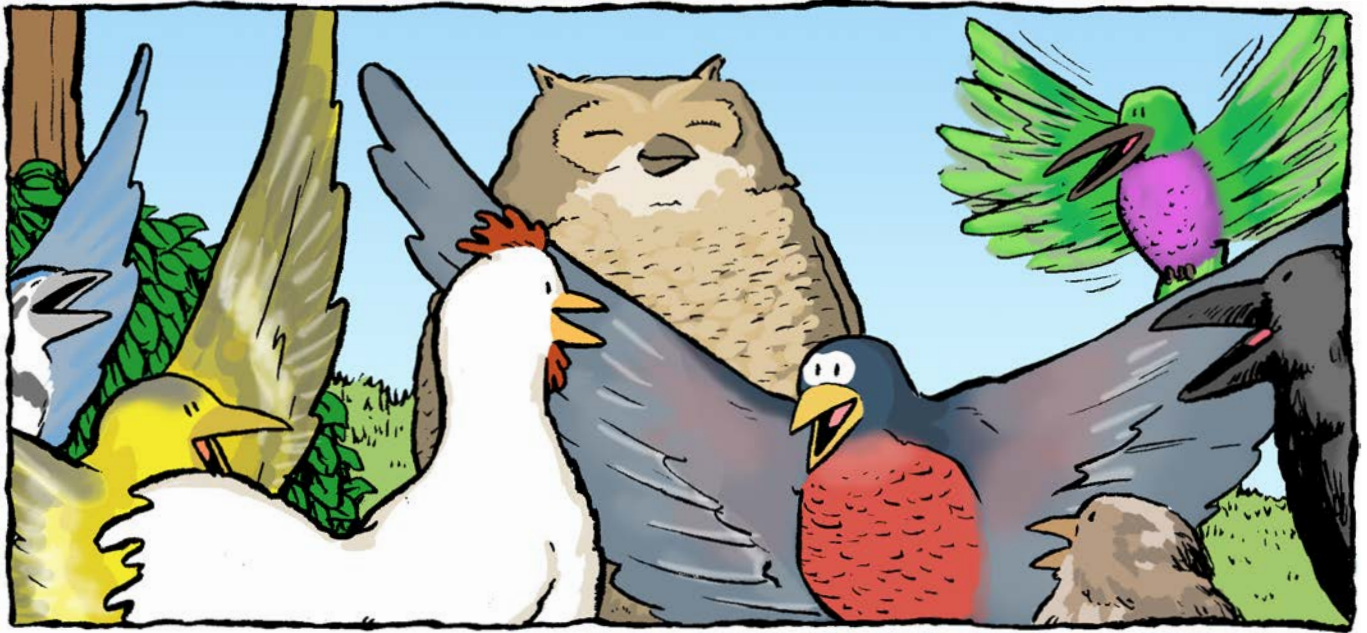
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"Robins' tracks will not look like
chickens' tracks if they hop," Owl said.

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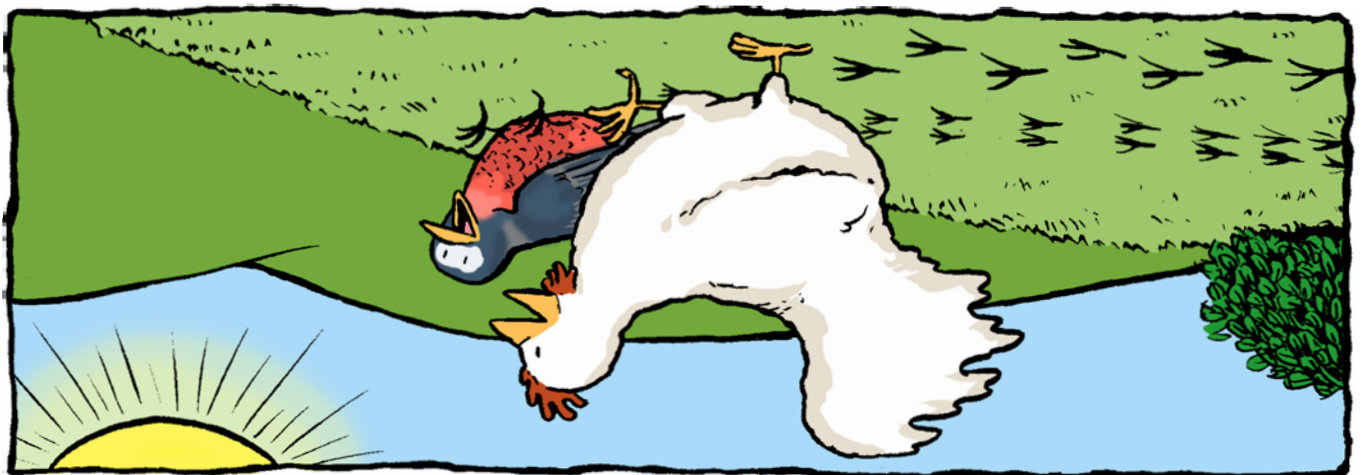
“Good, good!” cried all the birds.
They flapped their wings with joy.

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Chickens would walk with
one foot after the other.
Robins would hop.
Foxes would not get confused.





Owl was glad she could help the robins.
Now, she could sleep.

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From that day on,
foxes only chased chickens.
Robins could search the dirt
for worms in peace.

